Building PivotCharts in Excel

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Introduction

Building PivotCharts in Microsoft Excel is one of the most practical skills you can develop as a QA professional. A PivotChart does not simply display data; it stays connected to your source data, which means when new results are added, you can refresh the PivotChart to include the latest information and can be filtered interactively during a Sprint Review. This reading walks you through the exact steps to transform a raw test execution export into a clean, interactive quality dashboard in Excel.

Before you begin, make sure your raw test data file—for example, a .csv export from your test management tool—is open in Excel. The steps below use a dataset with three columns: **Test Case ID**, **Feature Area**, and **Status**.

Converting Your Data to an Excel Table

The first thing you need to do is turn your raw data range into a formal Excel Table. This is a critical foundation step; it makes your data source dynamic, meaning any new rows you add later will automatically be included when your PivotChart is refreshed.

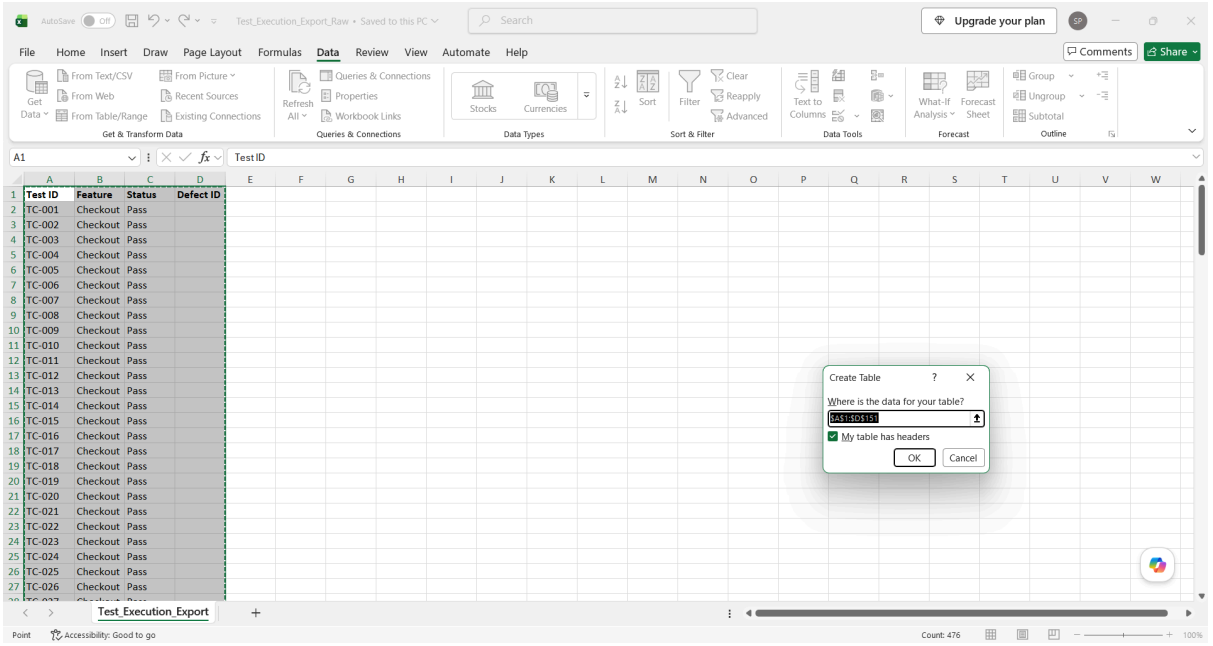
Step 1: Select a cell inside your data.

Select any cell inside your data range, for example, cell **A1**.

Step 2: Insert a Table.

On the top ribbon, select the **Insert** tab, then select **Table**. A dialog box called **Create Table** will appear. Excel automatically detects the boundaries of your data

and highlights the range. Confirm that the **My table has headers checkbox** is checked, then select **OK**.



The image displays an Excel spreadsheet interface containing a dataset on the left with columns for Test ID, Feature, Status, and Defect ID. In the foreground, a "Create Table" modal dialog box is open, showing a range input field set to =$A1:$D15 and a checked box for "My table has headers," with "OK" and "Cancel" buttons at the bottom.

Your data is now formatted as an official Excel Table, displayed with alternating blue and white row shading.

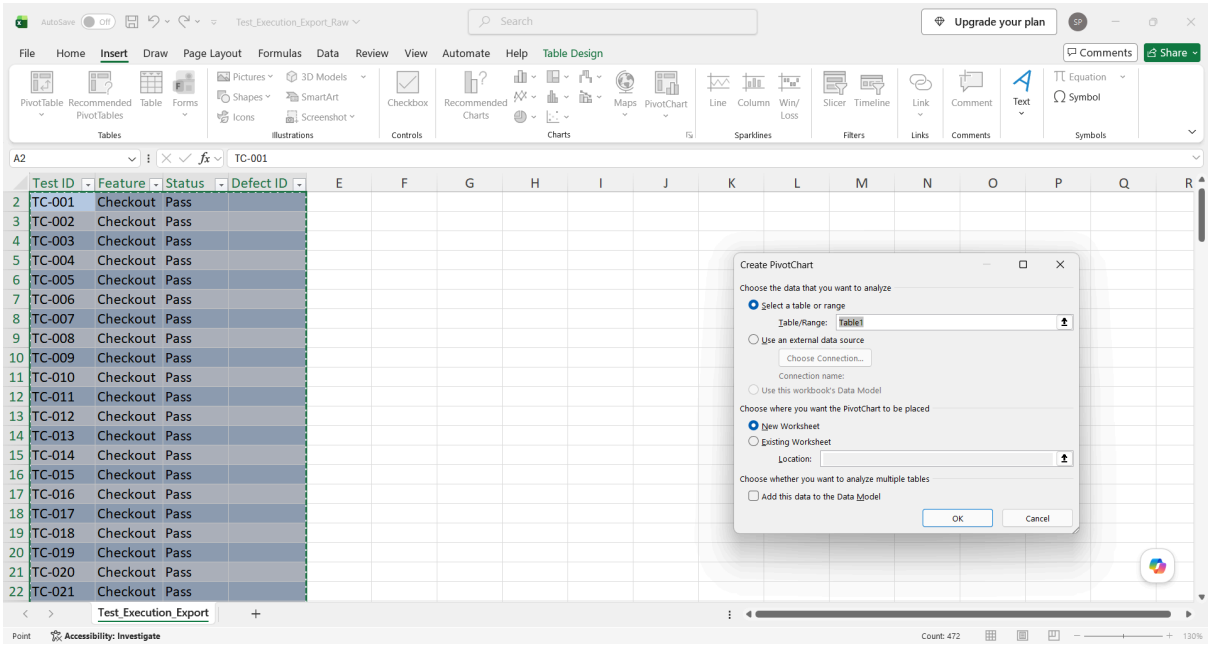
Key term: An **Excel Table** is a structured data range that expands dynamically. When you add new rows, any PivotChart connected to it will include that new data after a refresh.

Inserting a PivotChart

With any cell in your new Table selected, return to the **Insert** tab on the ribbon and this time select **PivotChart**.

Step 3: Open the PivotChart dialog.

The **Insert PivotChart** dialog box will open. It will confirm that **Table 1** is your data source and that the chart will be placed on a **New Worksheet**. Keep these default settings and select **OK**.

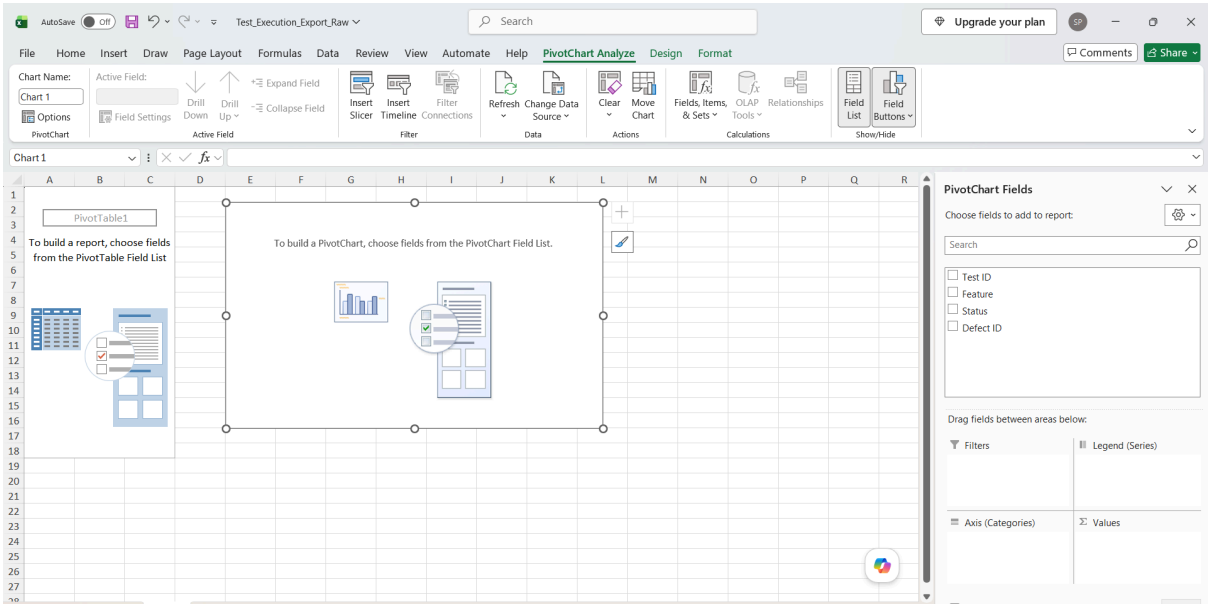


The image shows an Excel spreadsheet interface containing a highlighted table of test case data on the left with columns for Test Case ID, Feature Area, and Status. Overlaying the center of the spreadsheet is the "Create PivotChart" modal dialog box, which confirms "Table1" as the selected data range and shows options to place the PivotChart on a New Worksheet or Existing Worksheet, with "New Worksheet" selected. An OK button is present at the bottom right of the dialog box.

A new, blank worksheet will open. On the left side of the screen, you will see the empty PivotChart canvas. On the right side, the **PivotChart Fields** pane will appear, listing all your column headers: **Test Case ID**, **Feature Area**, and **Status**.

Configuring the PivotChart Fields

The **PivotChart Fields** pane is where you tell Excel how to organize and display your data. You will use three of the four drop zones at the bottom of this pane: **Axis (Categories)**, **Legend (Series)**, and **Values**.



The image shows a Microsoft Excel workbook containing a PivotTable - a tool for summarizing and analyzing data, and an associated stacked bar chart generated from test case data. On the left, a PivotTable summarizes test case counts across feature areas, alongside a PivotChart visually displaying the breakdown.

Follow these steps in order:

Step 4: Drag Feature Area into the Axis (Categories) box.

This sets your two features, Checkout and Profile, as the main groupings along the chart's horizontal axis.

Step 5: Drag Status into the Legend (Series) box.

This breaks each feature bar down by test status: Pass, Fail, and Blocked.

Step 6: Drag Test Case ID into the Values box.

At this point, the chart will begin to form on the left side of your screen. However, the Values box will read the Sum **of Test Case ID**, which is not meaningful for ID numbers. You need to change this to a count, which you will do in the next step.

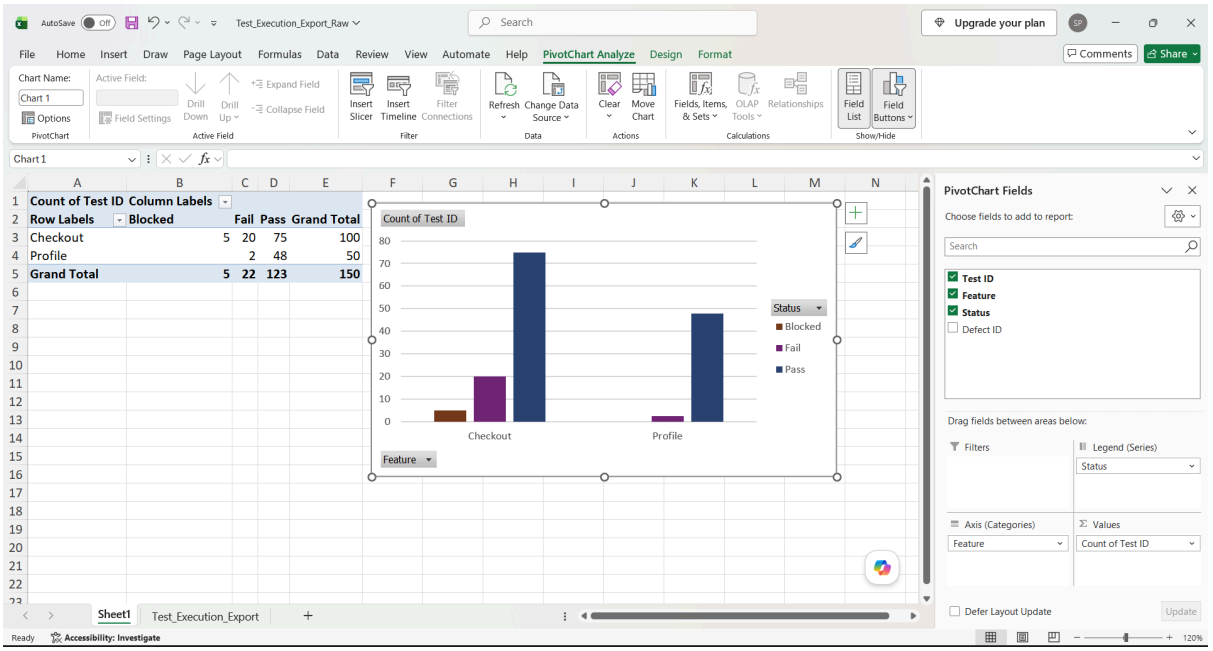
Warning: If you skip the next step and leave the aggregation set to Sum, your chart numbers will be incorrect and misleading. Always verify this setting before using the chart in a report.

Changing the Aggregation from Sum to Count

Step 7: Open Value Field Settings.

Test Case IDs are labels, not measurements. Adding IDs together does not provide useful information. Changing the calculation to Count tells Excel to count how many test cases exist for each status.

In the **Values** box, select **Sum of Test Case ID**. A small menu will appear. Select **Value Field Settings**.



This image displays a Microsoft Excel interface showing a PivotTable and an embedded PivotChart based on test execution data. On the left side of the worksheet, a grid summarizes the count of test IDs organized by feature categories along the rows, including Checkout, Profile, and a Grand Total row, cross-tabulated with status outcomes across columns labeled Blocked, Fail, Pass, and Grand Total. Checkout lists 5 Blocked, 20 Fail, and 75 Pass results totaling 100 tests, while Profile lists 0 Blocked, 2 Fail, and 48 Pass results totaling 50 tests, yielding a combined Grand Total of 150 tests across 5 Blocked, 22 Fail, and 123 Pass results. Embedded over the middle columns of the spreadsheet is a clustered bar chart visualizing this data, with the vertical y-axis measuring the count of test IDs from 0 to 80 and the horizontal x-axis displaying the feature categories Checkout and Profile. Vertical bar groups correspond to statuses indicated by color legend boxes to the right, showing brown for Blocked, purple for Fail, and dark navy blue for Pass, clearly highlighting high pass counts relative to lower fail and blocked counts. Positioned on the right sidebar is the PivotChart Fields panel, listing selected fields including Test ID, Feature, and Status checked, with Defect ID unchecked, and showing field assignments to drag areas where Status is assigned to Legend (Series), Feature to Axis (Categories), and Count of Test ID to Values. The top interface includes

standard Excel ribbon controls, displaying the PivotChart Analyze tab with tools for field settings, slicers, data refresh, and show/hide options.

Step 8: Select Count and confirm.

In the **Value Field Settings** dialog box, locate the **Summarize value field by** list. Select **Count**, then select **OK**.

Your chart will now update correctly. It will display stacked bars showing the count of Pass, Fail, and Blocked tests for both the Checkout and Profile features.

Cleaning Up the Chart

A functional chart is a good start, but a presentation-ready dashboard requires clean formatting. Removing unnecessary visual elements, also known as **chart junk,** makes your message clearer and your dashboard more professional.

Step 9: Hide the field buttons.

Gray interactive buttons appear on the chart by default. Choose any of them and select **Hide All Field Buttons on Chart**. The buttons will disappear, leaving a cleaner visual.

Step 10: Update the chart title.

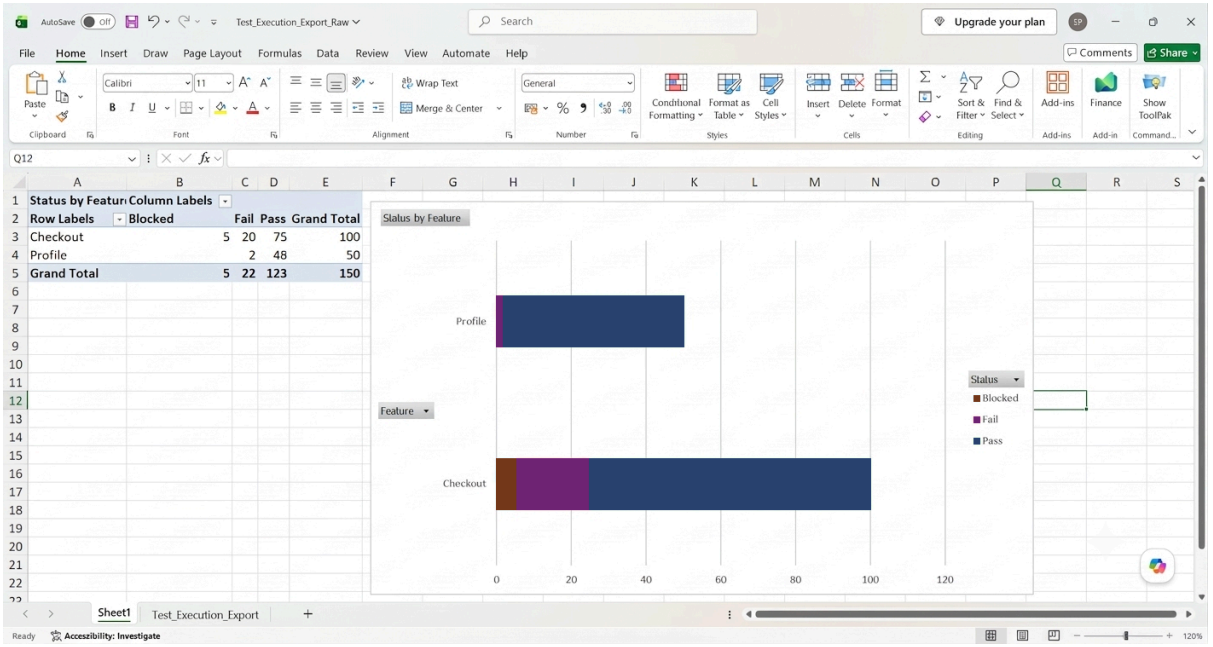
Select the chart title text box and replace the default title with something descriptive, such as **Test Status by Feature**. A clear title tells your audience exactly what they are reviewing without requiring them to study the chart.

Step 11: Remove the legend.

Select the legend on the side of the chart and press **Delete** on your keyboard. Because you will add data labels in the next step, the legend becomes redundant.

Step 12: Add data labels.

Choose any of the bars in the chart and select **Add Data Labels**. Exact counts will now appear on each bar segment, making the chart fully readable without additional explanation.



Status by Feature	Column Labels			
Row Labels	Blocked	Fail	Pass	Grand Total
Checkout	5	20	75	100
Profile		2	48	50
Grand Total	5	22	123	150

This screenshot displays a Microsoft Excel spreadsheet window featuring a pivot table on the upper-left side and a corresponding horizontal stacked bar chart placed in the center overlaying the grid area. The pivot table presents test execution metrics broken down by feature under "Row Labels" across "Column Labels" for status values: "Blocked", "Fail", "Pass", and "Grand Total". The row for "Checkout" lists 5 Blocked, 20 Fail, and 75 Pass results totaling 100 tests, while "Profile" lists 0 Blocked, 2 Fail, and 48 Pass results totaling 50 tests, summarizing into a Grand Total row of 5 Blocked, 22 Fail, and 123 Pass tests across 150 total executions. The stacked horizontal bar chart titled "Status by Feature" illustrates these metrics visually along a horizontal scale from 0 to 120, displaying two main horizontal bars for "Profile" at the top and "Checkout" at the bottom. The bar segments represent statuses using distinct colors matching the legend on the right: brown for Blocked, purple for Fail, and dark blue for Pass. The top bar for Profile shows a tiny purple Fail segment followed by a large blue Pass segment extending to 50, whereas the lower bar for Checkout shows a small brown Blocked segment from 0 to 5, a purple Fail segment from 5 to 25, and a long blue Pass segment continuing to 100. The Excel top navigation ribbon is visible above the spreadsheet showing standard tools under the "Home" tab, including clipboard options, font settings, alignment controls, conditional formatting, and cell styling tools, while the bottom status bar displays worksheet tab names labeled "Sheet1" and "Test_Execution_Export".

Key Considerations

Keep interactivity in mind. Because your chart is connected to an Excel Table through a PivotTable, it is fully interactive. You can use the filter icon within the PivotChart to show results for only one feature—for example, selecting only

Checkout will instantly update the chart to display only those results. This is especially useful during a Sprint Review when a stakeholder wants to go through the data for a specific area.

Remember to refresh. If you add new test results to your source file after the chart is built, select the chart and go to **PivotChart Analyze > Refresh** on the ribbon. The chart will update automatically to reflect the new data.

Verify the aggregation setting. If the Values box shows Sum instead of Count after you configure your fields, the chart numbers will be incorrect. Always confirm the Values box reads **Count of Test Case ID** before treating the chart as accurate.

Summary

You have now converted raw test data into a clean, interactive PivotChart dashboard in Excel. By formatting your data as a Table, configuring the PivotChart Fields pane, correcting the aggregation from Sum to Count, and removing chart junk, you have built a reusable reporting tool that updates automatically and communicates feature health clearly to any stakeholder.